

PickTogether

A collaborative group-voting website

Create a private room. Invite friends. Add choices. Vote together. Make the decision.

1. Project idea

PickTogether is a responsive website that helps a group make a shared decision. A host creates a private room and shares an invite link or code. Inside that room, the group can create separate polls for movies, restaurants, games, trips, meeting times, playlists, activities, or any other set of choices. Participants add options, vote, and view the final result according to rules selected by the host.

The problem

- Group decisions are often scattered across text messages, group chats, and several different apps.
- Suggestions get lost, people repeat the same choices, and the group may never reach a clear result.
- Most groups need a quick decision tool, not a complicated survey-building platform.

Our solution

- Keep each decision in one invite-only room with a clear title, list of choices, voting rules, and result.
- Allow one room to contain multiple poll tabs, so a group can decide several related questions in one place.
- Make joining and voting fast enough that friends will actually use it on a phone or computer.

Example uses

Use	Example decision
Movie night	Which movie should we watch?
Dinner	Which restaurant should we choose?
Trip planning	Which destination, date, or activity works best?
Gaming	Which game or mode should the group play?
Scheduling	Which meeting time works for the most people?

2. Shared vocabulary and user flow

Project vocabulary

Term	Meaning
Room	A private group space created by a host and accessed through an invite link or code.
Poll	One decision inside a room. Polls appear as separate tabs on the room page.
Option	A possible answer, such as a movie, restaurant, date, or activity.
Host	The person who creates the room and manages its polls and rules.
Participant	A person invited to join the room, add options when permitted, and vote.

Normal user flow

Step	User action	Expected result
1	Open the home page	Choose Create Room or Join Room.
2	Create or join	The host receives a code; a participant enters the code and a display name.
3	Enter the room	See the room title, participants, and poll tabs.
4	Open or create a poll	See its question, options, status, and voting rules.
5	Add options and vote	Valid choices are recorded and duplicate submissions are prevented.
6	Close the poll	Voting stops and the winning result is displayed.
7	Archive the room	The completed decisions remain viewable but cannot be changed.

Proposed pages

Page	Purpose
Home	Explain the product and provide Create and Join actions.
Create Room	Set the room name and generate an invite code.
Join Room	Enter an invite code and display name.
Room Dashboard	Show poll tabs, participants, and host controls.
Poll/Voting	Show the question and options; allow adding options and voting when enabled.
Results	Show vote totals, winner, ties, and poll status.

3. MVP scope: what we will build

The minimum viable product (MVP) is the version the team commits to finishing first. Everything below is required unless the team formally changes the scope together.

- Create a private room with a unique invite code or link.
- Join a room using the code and a display name.
- Create multiple polls inside one room and switch between them as tabs.
- Give each poll a question and two or more options.
- Allow the host to decide whether participants may add options.
- Prevent blank and clearly duplicate options.
- Allow each participant to cast one vote per poll and change it while the poll is open.
- Record vote totals correctly and prevent accidental duplicate votes.
- Allow the host to choose whether results are live or hidden until the poll closes.
- Allow the host to close a poll so no additional votes are accepted.
- Display the winner or clearly report a tie.
- Preserve rooms, polls, options, and votes after refreshing the page.
- Provide basic error messages for invalid codes, missing fields, and unavailable actions.
- Work at normal phone and desktop screen sizes.

Optional only after the MVP works

- Poll deadlines and countdowns.
- Anonymous voting controlled by the host.
- Random tie-breaker chosen by the host.
- Images or external information for choices such as movie posters.
- Account registration, saved room history, and email notifications.
- Ranked-choice or multi-select voting.

STOP LINE

The class-project version is complete when a host can create a room, invite another person, create at least two poll tabs, add choices, collect votes, close a poll, and display a persistent winner or tie on both phone and desktop layouts.

4. What we are deliberately not building

- No native iPhone or Android application; the deliverable is a responsive website.
- No payments, subscriptions, advertisements, or marketplace.
- No public social network, follower system, private messaging, or full group chat.
- No video or music streaming inside the website.
- No AI recommendation system in the MVP.
- No maps, delivery ordering, ticket purchasing, or reservation system.
- No complicated election security or political/public-government voting use case.
- No more than the selected voting modes until the basic single-choice workflow is reliable.

Starter user-story backlog

These stories are a starting point for the formal user-story milestone. Owners can be assigned after the team list is finalized.

#	Story name	User story	Owner
1	Create a Room	As a host, I want to create a private room so that my group has one place to make decisions.	TBD
2	Invite Friends	As a host, I want a shareable code or link so that I can invite participants quickly.	TBD
3	Join a Room	As a participant, I want to join with a code and display name so that I can vote without a complicated setup.	TBD
4	Create Multiple Polls	As a host, I want several poll tabs in one room so that the group can decide more than one related question.	TBD
5	Add an Option	As an authorized participant, I want to suggest an option so that my preference can be considered.	TBD
6	Cast a Vote	As a participant, I want to select an option so that my preference contributes to the decision.	TBD
7	Change a Vote	As a participant, I want to change my vote while the poll is open so that I can reconsider before the deadline.	TBD
8	Control Result Visibility	As a host, I want to show live results or hide them until closing so that I can choose a fair voting style.	TBD
9	Close Voting	As a host, I want to close a poll so that the decision becomes final.	TBD
10	See the Winner	As a participant, I want a clear winner or tie message so that the group knows the outcome.	TBD
11	Recover After Refresh	As a participant, I want the room and my recorded vote to remain after a refresh so that progress is not lost.	TBD
12	Use Any Screen Size	As a participant, I want the site to work on my phone and computer so that I can vote from the device I have.	TBD

5. Suggested team split

The work can be divided by feature area while every member still participates in reviews and testing.

Area	Main responsibility	Likely outputs
Interface & navigation	Overall layout, responsive pages, room tabs, accessibility.	Home, join, dashboard, reusable styles.
Rooms & invitations	Room creation, codes, joining, participants, host identity.	Room pages, invite flow, validation.
Polls & options	Poll creation, tab switching, choices, duplicate detection.	Poll forms, option management, API routes.
Voting & results	Vote rules, totals, result visibility, closing and ties.	Voting controls, results view, tests.
Data, quality & deployment	Database design, persistence, integration tests, deployment.	Schema, setup guide, hosted build, QA checklist.

If the team has four members, combine Interface with Rooms. If the team has six members, separate quality/testing from data/deployment.

Recommended technical direction

Layer	Recommended starting choice	Reason
Frontend	HTML, CSS, and JavaScript	Matches current coursework and keeps the interface understandable.
Backend	Node.js with Express	Uses JavaScript on both client and server and provides simple API routes.
Database	SQLite for development	Easy local setup and sufficient for a class-sized application.
Source control	GitHub with feature branches	Supports individual ownership, reviews, and visible contribution history.

Simple data model

- Room: id, name, invite code, host identifier, status.
- Participant: id, room id, display name, host flag.
- Poll: id, room id, question, result-visibility rule, open/closed status.
- Option: id, poll id, text, creator, active status.
- Vote: id, poll id, option id, participant id. One active vote per participant per poll for the MVP.

6. Build order and team decisions

Phase	Goal	Exit condition
1. Agree	Finalize vocabulary, voting rules, page sketches, and story owners.	Everyone can explain the same MVP and stop line.
2. Skeleton	Create repository, basic pages, server, and database schema.	The project runs locally for every member.
3. Room flow	Build create-room, invite, join, and dashboard behavior.	Two browsers can enter the same room.
4. Poll flow	Build polls, tabs, options, votes, and persistence.	Votes remain correct after refreshing.
5. Results	Add visibility rules, closing, winner/tie display, and host controls.	The complete decision flow works end to end.
6. Finish	Responsive design, accessibility, validation, tests, documentation, deployment.	MVP demo passes the shared checklist.

Decisions the team should make together

- Final project name: PickTogether or another name.
- Will participants join as guests, or must everyone create an account? Recommendation: guests for the MVP.
- Can participants add options by default? Recommendation: host-controlled setting.
- Can a participant change a vote? Recommendation: yes, until the poll closes.
- Are results live or hidden? Recommendation: host chooses per poll.
- What happens in a tie? Recommendation: report the tie first; random tie-breaking is optional.
- Which member owns each user story and technical area?

Final shared definition of success

During the final demonstration, one team member creates a room and two poll tabs. A second person joins from another browser, adds or views options, casts a vote, and changes it. The host closes the poll, both users see the correct winner or tie, and the result remains after a refresh. The same flow is usable on a phone-sized screen.

This document defines a practical first version. New ideas belong in the optional backlog until the MVP is complete.